trousers, Kanshi Ram was a straight-talking politician. ‘Ambedkar has been reduced to a statue in Maharashtra—it is we in UP who are taking his legacy forward,’ he once told me.

Serving us tea at their Humayun Road residence would be Mayawati, already the leader of the party in UP but playing hostess to Kanshi Ram in Delhi. I never asked Kanshi Ram about his relationship with her, but it was apparent that he saw her as his obvious successor. ‘She is much stronger than me. *Woh ek din raaj karengi!*’ (One day she will rule.)

He was bang on. I was in Lucknow when Mayawati was sworn in as the country’s first Dalit woman chief minister in June 1995. It was a news event I shall not forget. Just a day earlier, Mayawati, who had withdrawn support to the Mulayam Singh government, had been attacked by SP workers in what was infamously described as the ‘state guest house’ incident. We didn’t have a twenty-four-hour news network at the time, but the images were frightening—MLAs of the Samajwadi Party chasing Mayawati and her men through the corridors of the building while the police remained mute spectators. Fearing for her life, Mayawati had to lock herself in a room. I interviewed her a few days later and she claimed that the incident had changed her forever. *‘Yeh mera murder karna chahte thhe. Inko mein kabhi nahin chodoongi, inko sabak seekhana padega’* (They wanted to kill me, I will teach them all a lesson).

Over the next two decades, Mayawati did teach her opponents a fearsome lesson. Her politics was ruthlessly unforgiving. making and breaking governments. It was her style to keep her political opponents guessing, a lesson she had learnt from Kanshi Ram who believed that political power was the ‘master key’ that would eventually open the door to Dalit liberation. She was tough on law and order, but was also accused, like Jayalalithaa, of massive corruption. A UP businessman once told me, ‘It’s a straight deal in UP. Pay Mayawati money, get your work done. No middlemen needed.’

Like Jayalalithaa, she, too, could be a daunting presence. She would rarely meet the media, but I did meet her once in her rather opulent residence in Lucknow. A few weeks earlier, BSP supporters had broken our OB van and almost bashed up the driver over a story we had done on